

"INFORM..."

Public Service Broadcasting's "The Race for Space" (2015) captures one of the most defining periods of human history...

THE SPACE RACE between the United States and the Soviet Union. The album uses real archival audio from landmark events. the album transforms scientific progress into a artistic narrative. I like how this album combines history and creativity, using music to educate people.

Online reviews of "The Race For Space"

"Genuinely original, innovating and amazing" Artrocker Album of the Month

"Inspirational stuff" Time Out

"Absolutely, sensationally brilliant" Top 10 Albums of 2013' BBC6 Music:

"Adrenalised post-rock and electronics...gripping" Q* Mojo

"A sampladelic delight" Q* Independent



EDUCATE...ENTERTAIN."

Track 1: The Race for Space

The opening track, *The Race for Space*, sets the stage by sampling President John F. Kennedy's iconic 1962 speech at Rice University, in which he declares:

"We choose to go to the Moon in this decade and do the other things, not because they are easy, but because they are hard." President John F. Kennedy

Track 2: Sputnik

The track *Sputnik* symbolises the beginning of this journey. Using the repetitive beeping of the first satellite, launched in 1957, Public Service Broadcasting turn a simple radio signal into rhythm and atmosphere. The minimalist sound reflects the purity and isolation of early space exploration, while also suggesting the shock it caused on Earth. For me, it's like the audio equivalent of a cold, modernist sculpture — simple, yet carrying enormous meaning about progress and perspective.

Track 3: Gagarin

The first man in space — smiling, waving, looking completely fearless. Yuri Gagarin became a sort of universal icon, representing humanities first journey into the universe off planet Earth. I like the video for this song as it shows astronauts break dancing.



Gagarin



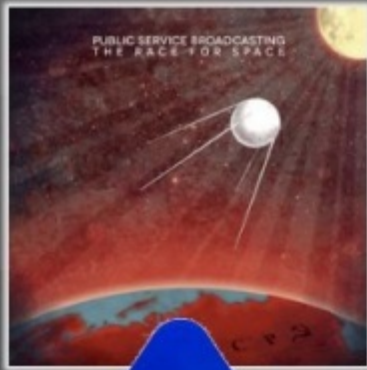
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Track 4: Fire in the Cockpit

On January 27th, 1967, astronauts "Gus" Grissom, Ed White and Roger Chaffee were killed in a tragic accident during a launch rehearsal for the first flight of the Apollo spacecraft that would take humans to the moon

Just one year later, Apollo 7 and Apollo 8 would rise from the ashes to take men back into Earth orbit and around the Moon for the first time respectively



Track 5: E.V.A.

E.V.A., short for Extravehicular Activity, celebrates the first spacewalks. It captures the FEELING of floating in the vacuum of space. The repetition of samples gives a feeling of distance and detachment, as though we're hearing echoes across time.

Track 6: The Other Side

In The Other Side, the listener experiences the tension of Apollo 8 as it passes behind the Moon and temporarily loses radio contact with Earth. The silence and static create suspense, and when communication is finally restored, there's a sense of relief. This track captures the emotional reality of space exploration: not just adventure, but isolation, anxiety, and faith.

Track 8: Valentina

Valentina Tereshkova, a Soviet skydiver, was the first woman to go to space. She spent three days in orbit – longer than all the Americans put together at that time – but suffered from space sickness and technical problems.

There aren't many recordings of her voice in space – the problems with the mission meant that the Soviets were unwilling to publicize it much – and of course, she only spoke Russian. The band Smoke Fairies sing harmonies over this track to cover that up

Track 9: Tomorrow

The final track, Tomorrow, feels reflective and almost melancholic. After all the triumph and noise, it leaves space for thought. The music fades slowly, suggesting both the end of an era and the beginning of another question: what's next? It's like the silence after finishing a painting – when the work is done, but the ideas linger. It captures the uncertainty that follows achievement, mirroring how humanity continues to look upwards, searching for purpose beyond success.





"The idea of using Sputnik's signal to drive the song itself came relatively early on, as did the idea of trying to give the song a more general atmosphere of pulsing, electronic menace. For the Americans to hear this Soviet voice broadcasting from orbit above them must've been deeply unsettling; equally, for the Soviets to know it was up there must have been both awe- and pride-inspiring."

Sputnik

J. Willgoose, Esq., in the liner notes of the CD release of *The Race for Space* explaining how they used the audio signal sample of the noise that the satellite made in the track. I like the way it is mixed in with the music but is not that obvious. I only found this out during the research for *I/O* even though I had heard the song before.

